



PARISHRAM 2027

Lecture 2

THE LAST LESSON

(Part - 02)

English

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Topics to be Covered

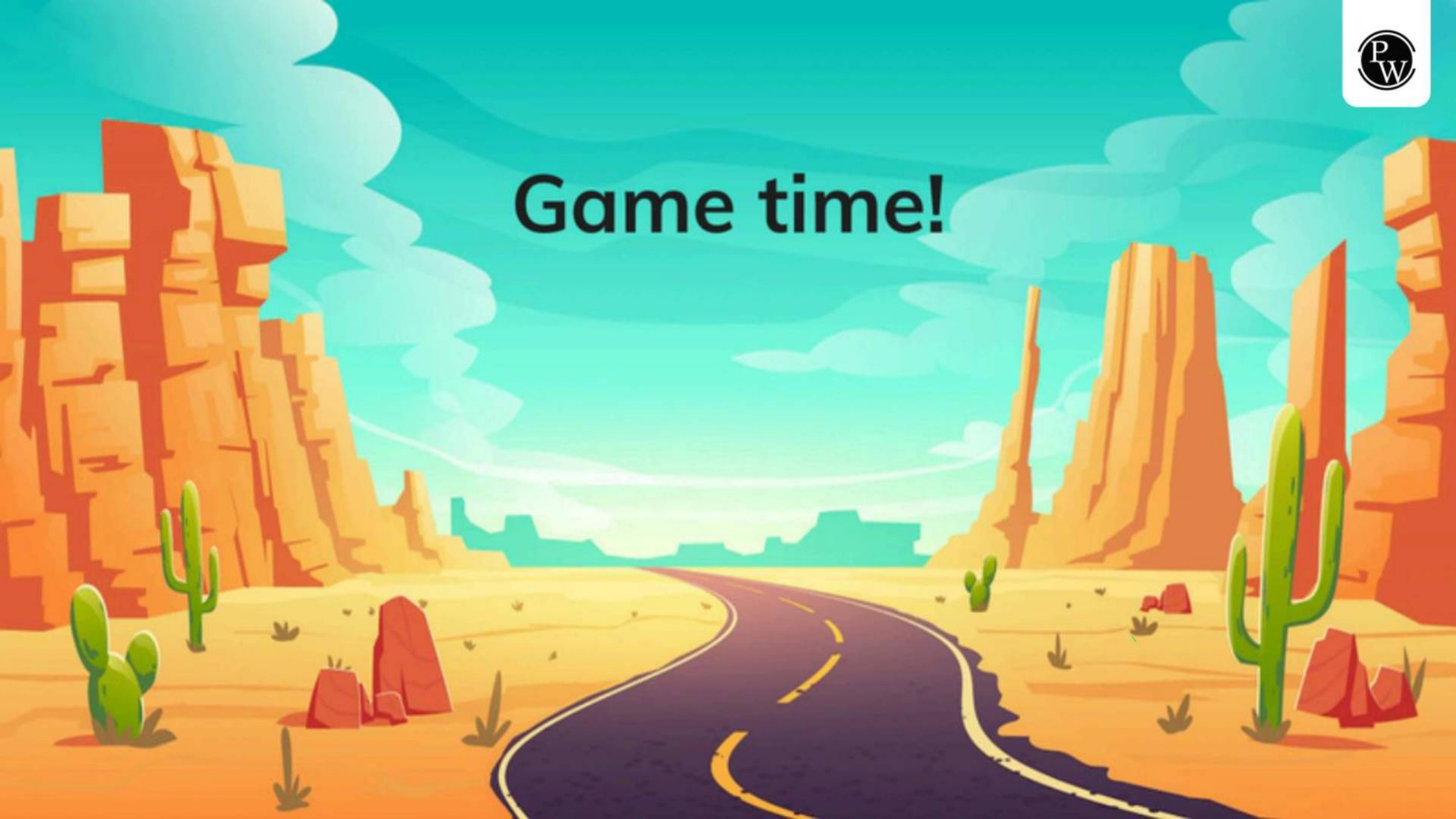
1 Game

2 Flamingo: The Last Lesson :II

3 Questions



Game time!



Spot the differences!

1



2



1. sign board, buildings, tree, plane, compass, sky, watch, road
2. scroll, rock, windows, bushes, tree, pillars, animals, map, lighthouse
3. sign board, scroll, compass, volcanic eruption, windows, flowers, clouds, birds

1



Here are the
eight differences!

2



3. sign board, scroll, compass,
volcanic eruption, windows,
flowers, clouds, birds

Question 1



They gave him the cold shoulder after the argument.

A) Apologize to someone

B) Help someone

C) Offer support

✓ D) To intentionally ignore or treat someone in an unfriendly way

Question 2

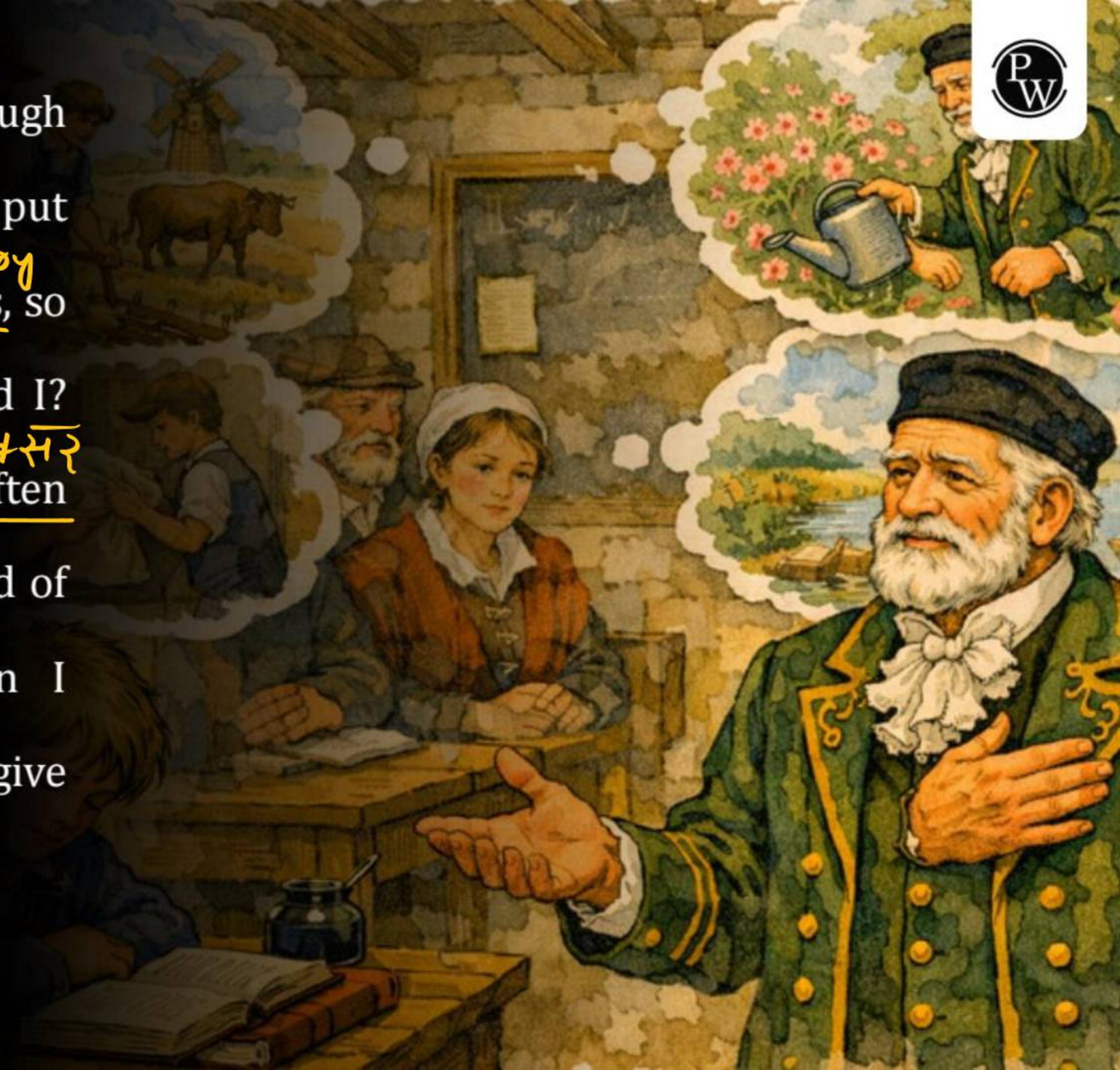


Despite the pain, she decided to bite the bullet and finish the marathon.

- ☒ **A) Face a difficult situation bravely**
- ☐ **B) Make a quick decision**
- ☐ **C) Ignore the pain**
- ☐ **D) Avoid the problem**

Concerned

“Your parents were not anxious enough to have you learn. They preferred to put you to work on a farm or at the factory mills, so as to have a little more money. And I? दोषी अवसर I’ve been to blame also. Have I not often sent you to water my flowers instead of learning your lessons? And when I wanted to go fishing, did I not just give you a holiday?”



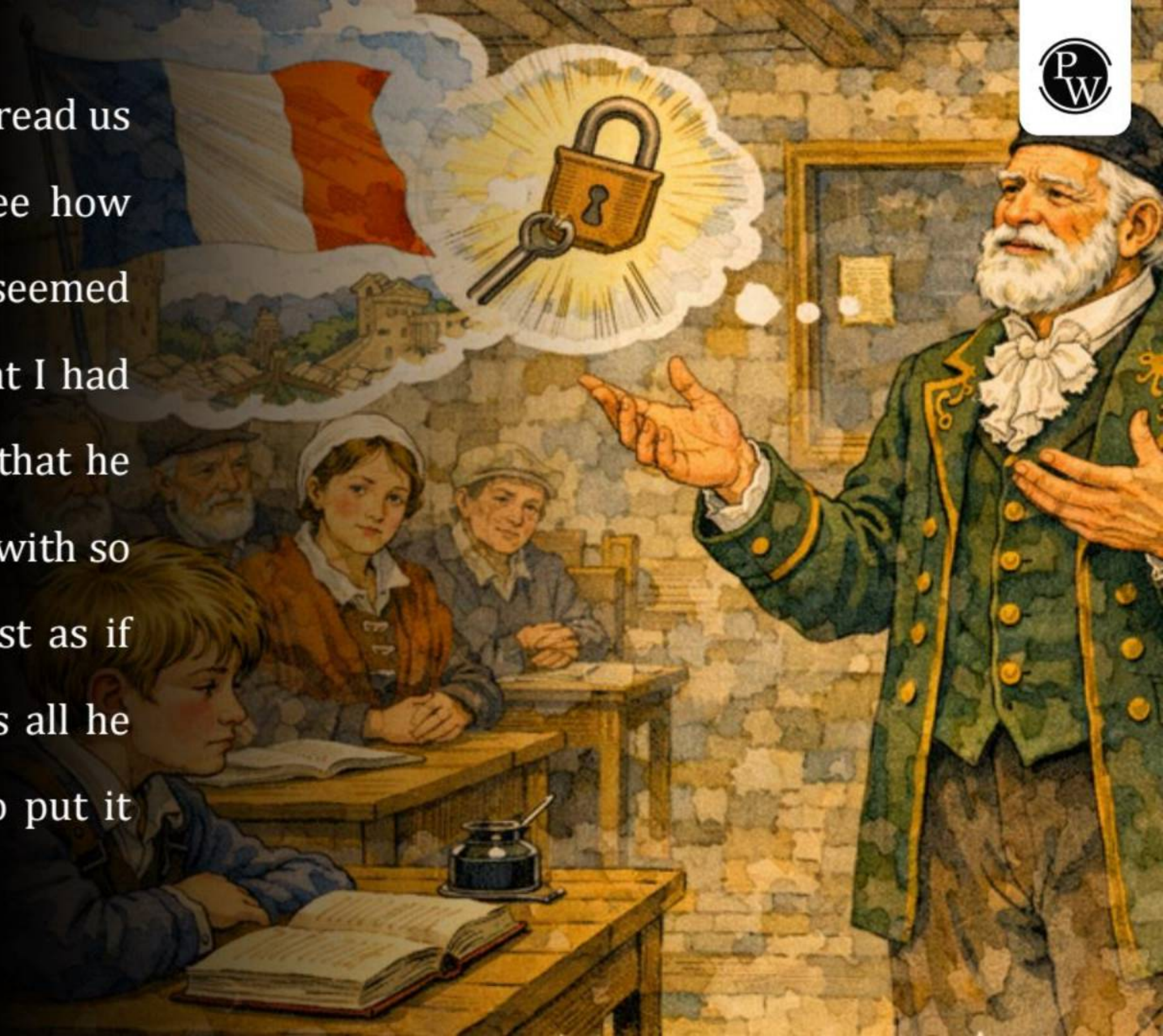
Then, from one thing to another, M. Hamel went on to talk of the French language, saying that it was the most beautiful language in the world — the clearest, the

most logical; that we must ^{protect} guard it among us and never forget it, because when a ^{made slaves} people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language it is as if they had the key to their prison.

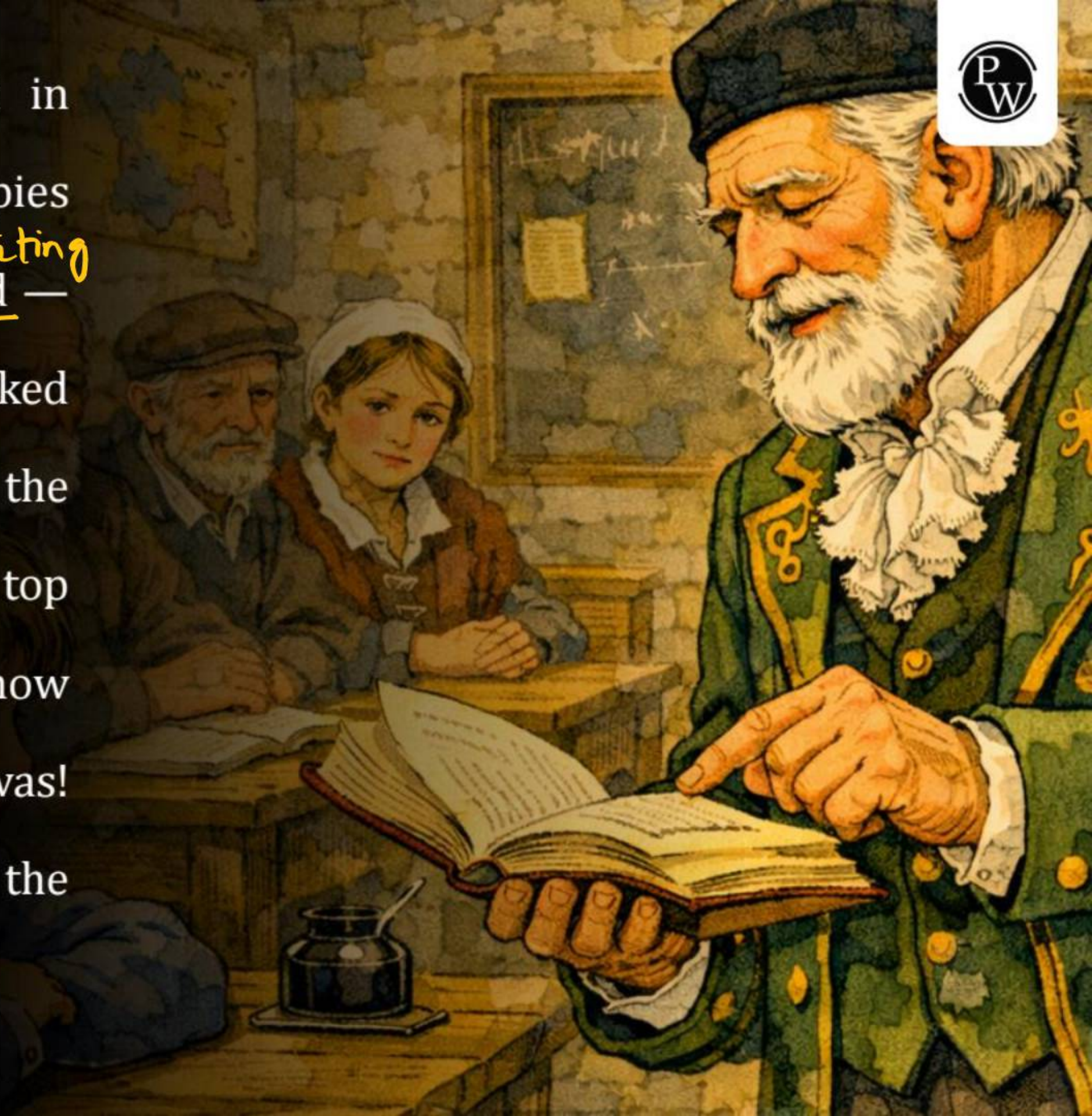
^{hold firmly}



Then he opened a grammar and read us our lesson. I was amazed to see how well I understood it. All he said seemed so easy, so easy! I think, too, that I had never listened so carefully, and that he had never explained everything with so much patience. It seemed almost as if the poor man wanted to give us all he knew before going away, and to put it all into our heads at one go at one stroke.



After the grammar, we had a lesson in writing. That day M. Hamel had new copies *handwriting* for us, written in a beautiful round hand — France, Alsace, France, Alsace. They looked like little flags floating everywhere in the school-room, hung from the rod at the top of our desks. You ought to have seen how everyone *began working* set to work, and how quiet it was! The only sound was the scratching of the pens over the paper. *Lough sound*



insects

Once some beetles flew in; but nobody paid any attention to them, not even the *Smallest kids* littlest ones, who worked right on *copying* tracing their fish-shape of fish hook hooks, as if that was French, too.

On the roof the pigeons cooed very low, and I thought to myself, "Will

they make them sing in German,

even the pigeons?"



Question 1



Where did the parents send their children?

A) School

B) Coaching

C) Movies

 **D) Farms and mills**

Question 2



What was M. Hamel's opinion about the French language? ✨

- A) It was the most difficult language in the world.
- B) It was inferior to other languages.
- ✓ C) It was the most beautiful, clear, and logical language.
- D) It was irrelevant to the people's freedom.

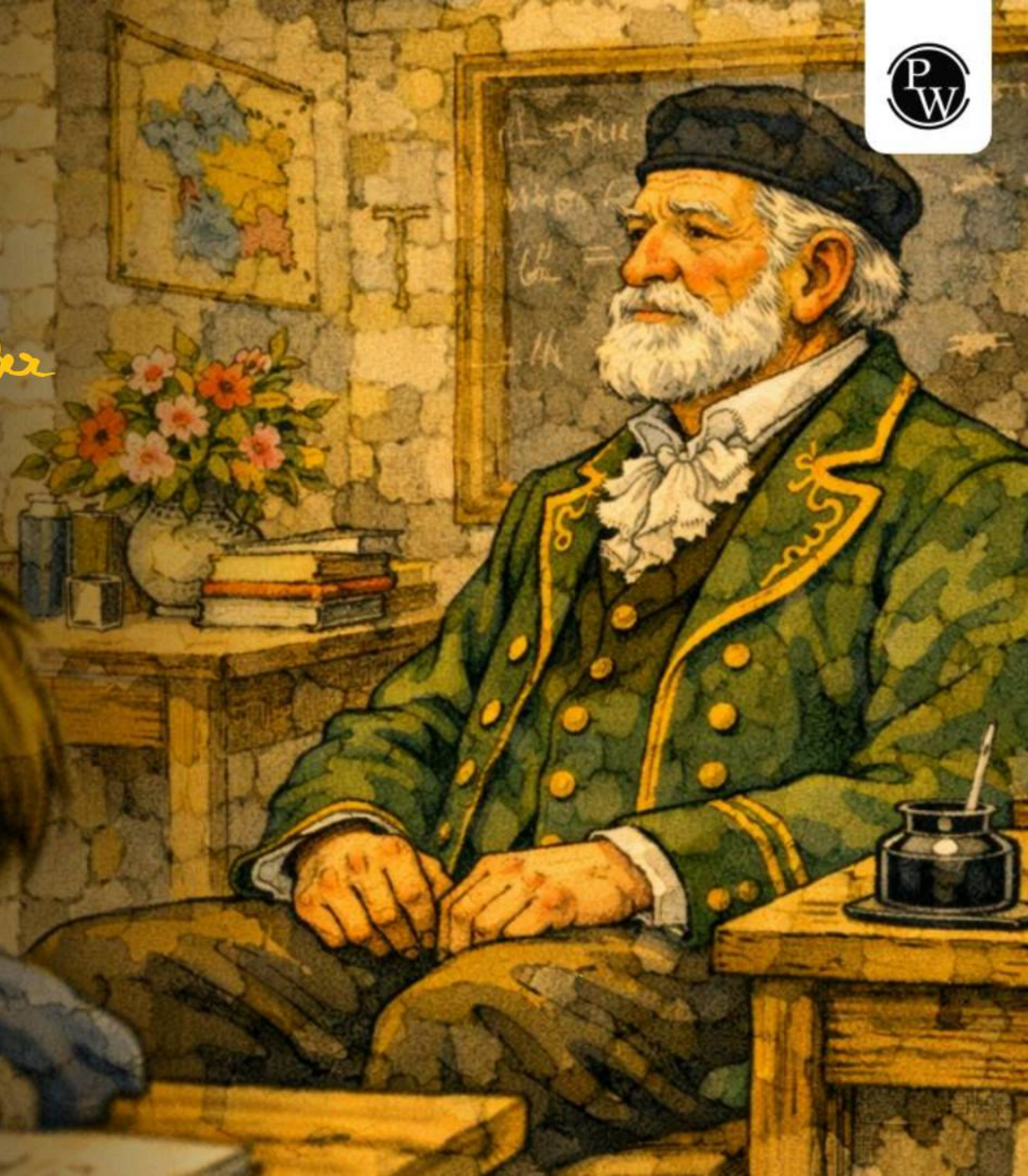
Question 3



Why did M. Hamel emphasize the importance of the French language?

- A) Because he wanted to impress the students.
- ✓ B) Because he believed it was necessary for cultural preservation.
- C) Because he disliked other languages.
- D) Because he wanted to make the students feel guilty.

Whenever I looked up from my writing,
I saw M. Hamel sitting still motionless in his
chair and staring gazing first at one thing, then
at another, as if he wanted to permanently remember fix in his
mind just how everything looked in that
little school-room. Imagine Fancy! For forty
years he had been there in the same
place, with his garden outside the
window and his class in front of him,
just like that.



Only the desks and benches had been *become smooth because of usage* worn smooth; the walnut-trees in the garden were taller, and the *hop* hopvine that he had planted himself *Worked around* twined about the windows to the roof. How it must have broken his heart to leave it all, poor man; to hear his sister moving about in the room above, packing their trunks! For they must leave the country next day.



teach

But he had the courage to hear every lesson to the very last. After the writing, we had a lesson in history, and then the babies chanted their ba, be, bi, bo, bu.

Down there at the back of the room old

Wore

Hauser had put on his spectacles and, holding his beginner's book primer in both hands, spelled

the letters with them. You could see that

shake

he, too, was crying; his voice trembled with emotion,

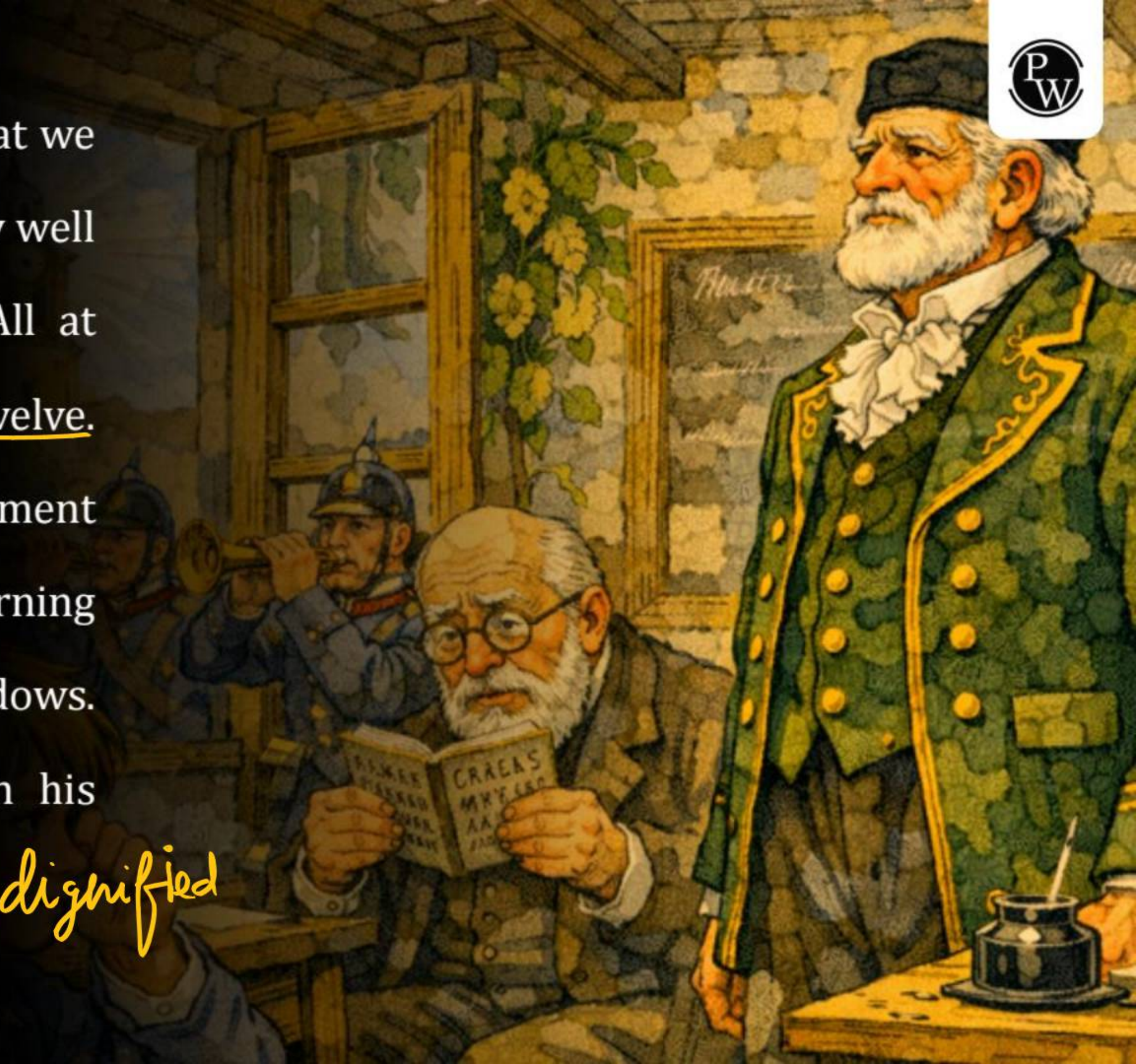


and it was so funny to hear him that we
all wanted to laugh and cry. Ah, how well
I remember it, that last lesson! All at
once the church-clock struck twelve.

Then the ^{bell} Angelus. At the same moment
the ^{musical ins.} trumpets of the Prussians, returning
from drill, sounded under our windows.

M. Hamel stood up, very pale, in his
chair; I never saw him look so tall.

dignified



“My friends,” said he, “I—I—” But something choked him. He could not go

Continue

on. Then he turned to the blackboard,

took a piece of chalk, and, *using* bearing on
strength

with all his might, he wrote as large as

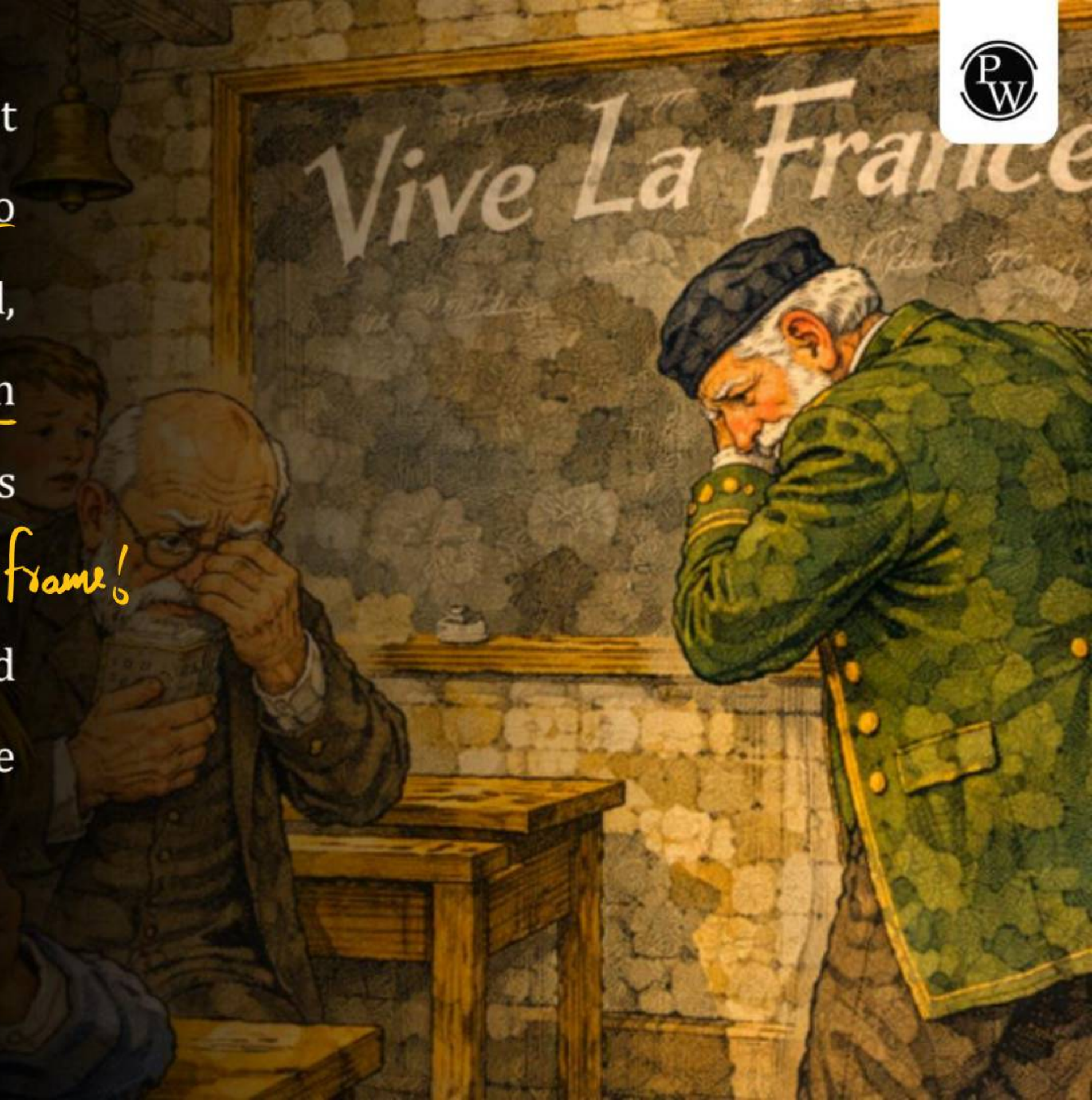
he could—“Vive La France!” *long live, France!*

Then he stopped and leaned his head

against the wall, and, without a word, he

सुकाया
इशारा
made a gesture to us with his hand—

“School is dismissed—you may go.



Message:



- ① Inculcate deep love for your country.
- ② Do not postpone things — *Carpe Diem!*
- ③ Be loyal, honest, hardworking in your work.

Question 1



How does the narrator describe M. Hamel's demeanor during the final lesson?

- A) Busy and energetic ✗
- ✓ B) Emotional and reflective
- C) Strict and authoritative ✗
- D) Indifferent and detached ✗

Question 2



How does M. Hamel's writing of "Vive La France!" on the blackboard reflect his feelings?

- A) It shows his anger towards the students.**
- ✓ B) It expresses his desire to instill patriotism in the students.**
- C) It symbolizes his resignation to the situation.**
- D) It indicates his eagerness to leave.**

Question 3



The story **"The Last Lesson"** highlights the human tendency of:

A) Dishonesty

^{postpone}
✓ B) Procrastination

C) Being courageous

D) Being a coward

Notice the underlined words in these sentences and tick the option that best explains their meaning. (NCERT)

“What a thunderclap these words were to me!”

a. The words were _____

i. loud and clear.

 **ii. startling and unexpected.**

iii. pleasant and welcome.

“When a people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language it is as if they had the key to their prison”

b. It is as if they have the key to the prison as long as they _____

i. do not lose their language.

✓ ii. are attached to their language.

iii. quickly learn the conqueror's language.

✗

Don't go so fast, you will get to your school in plenty of time.

c. You will get to your school_____.

i. very late. ✗

ii. too early.

✓ iii. early enough.

Key Points:



Franz's fears while going to school

- late for school
- dreads teacher's scolding
- had not learnt his lesson on participles
- thinks of running away & spending the day outside as:
 - the day was warm & bright with birds chirping
 - he was tempted to watch the Prussian soldiers drilling
- overcomes temptations and hurries to school



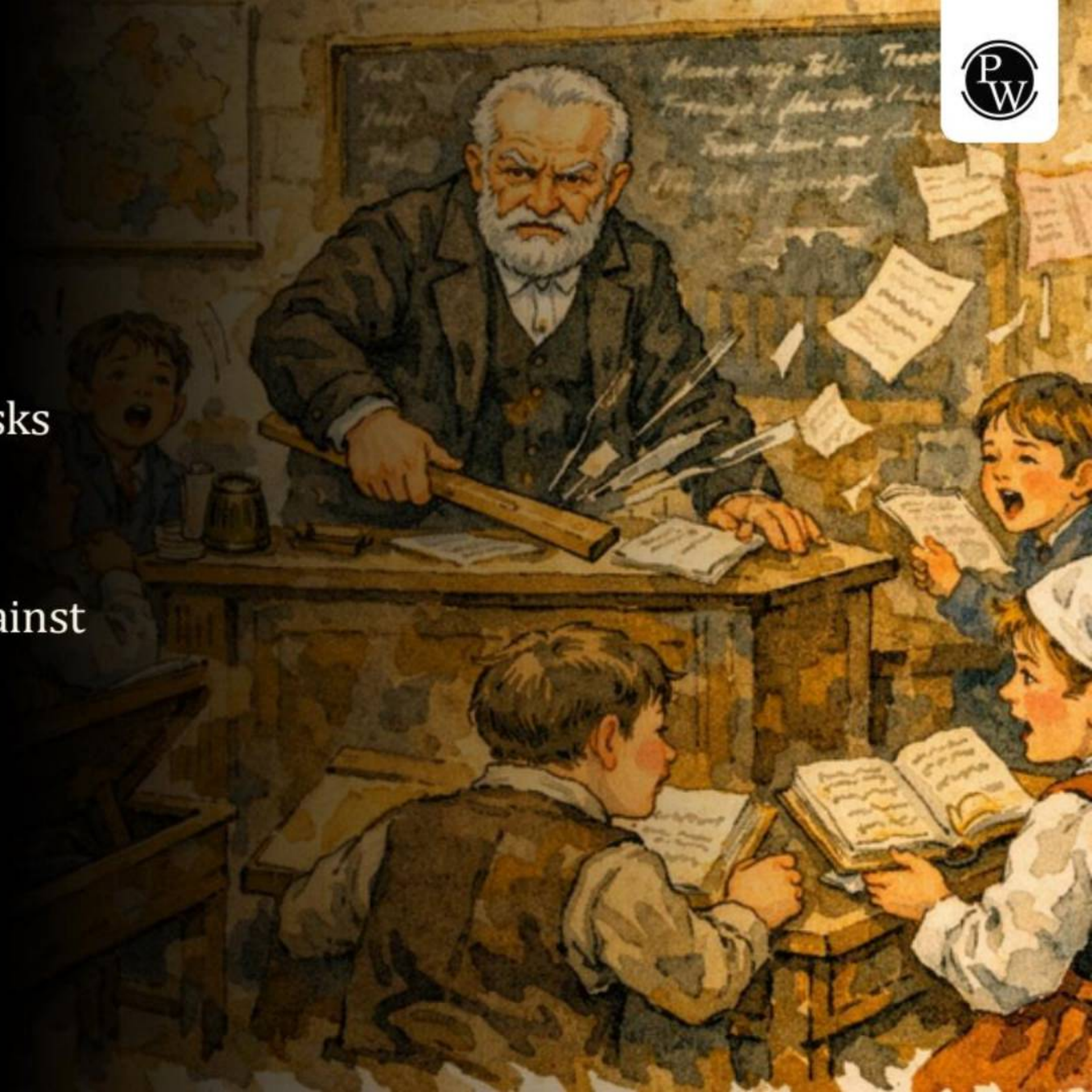
Scene at the town hall

- a crowd in front of the bulletin-board
- it was source of all bad news: the lost battles, the draft, the orders of the commanding officer
- Franz worries what the matter could be
- astounded by the blacksmith's remark that there was plenty of time to reach school



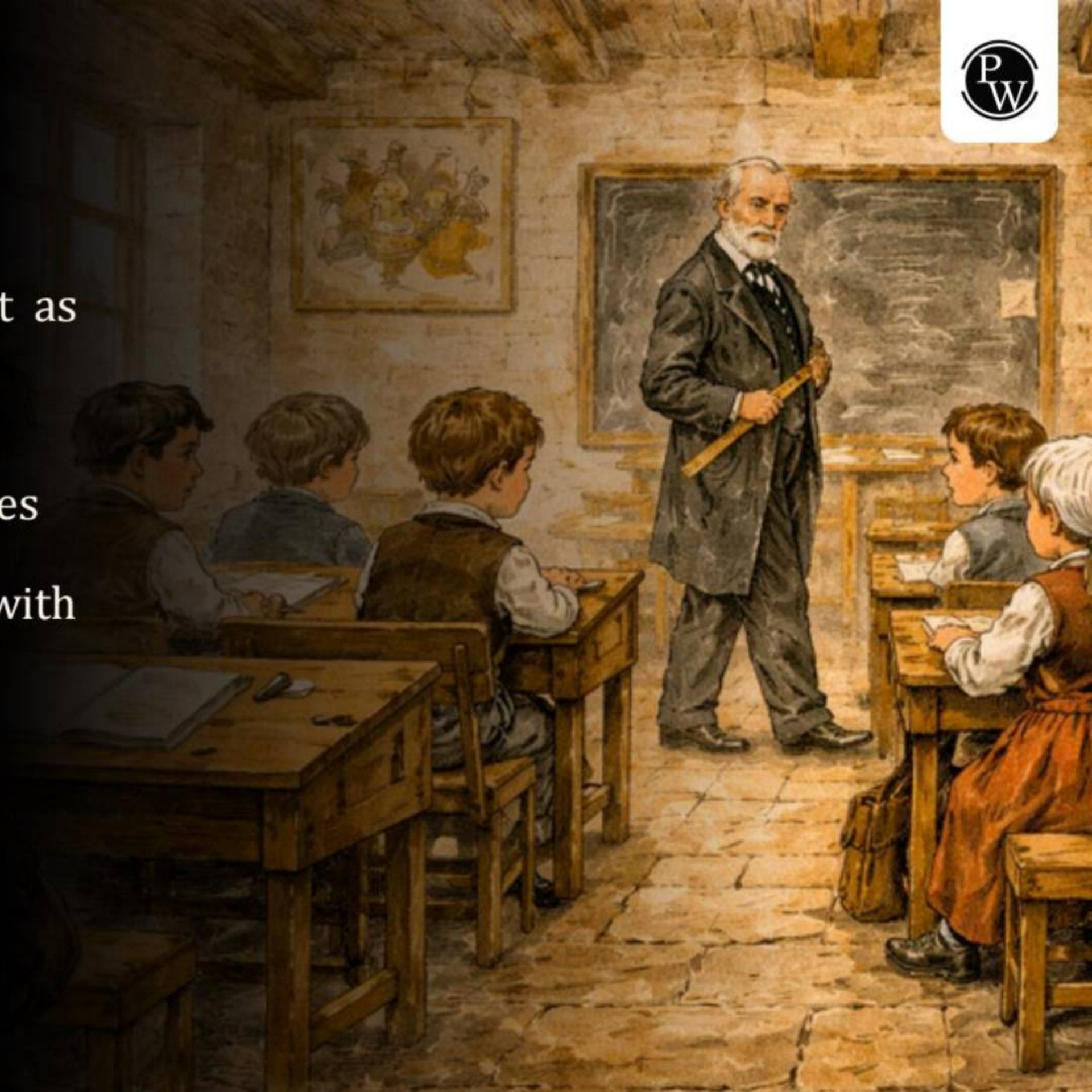
Usual scene at school

- began with a great bustle
- noise of opening and closing of desks
- lessons repeated loudly in unison
- teacher's ruler striking hard against the table



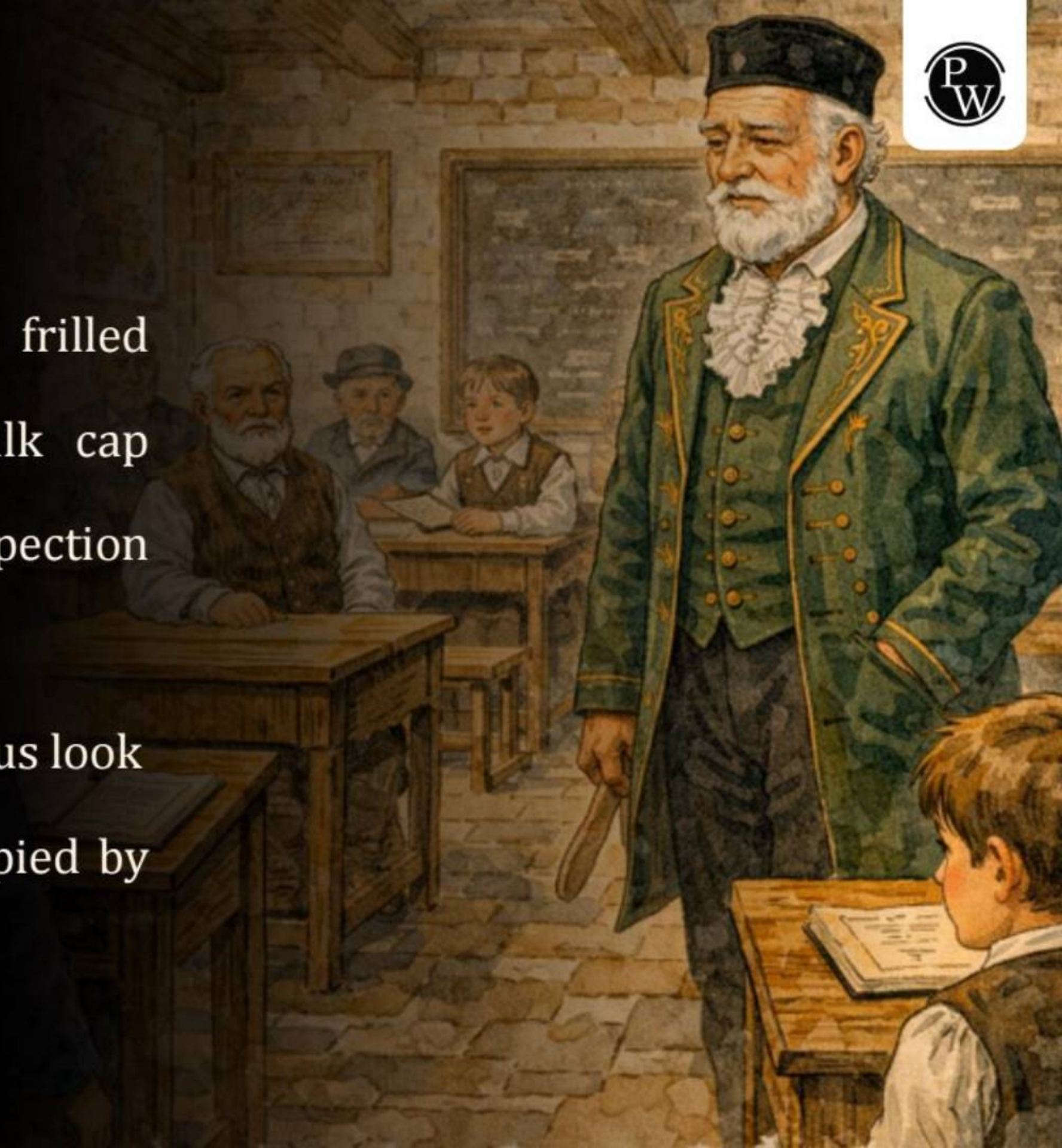
Changed scenario that day

- everything very still and as quiet as Sunday morning
- all classmates already in their places
- M. Hamel pacing up and down with the ruler under his arm
- Franz frightened to enter



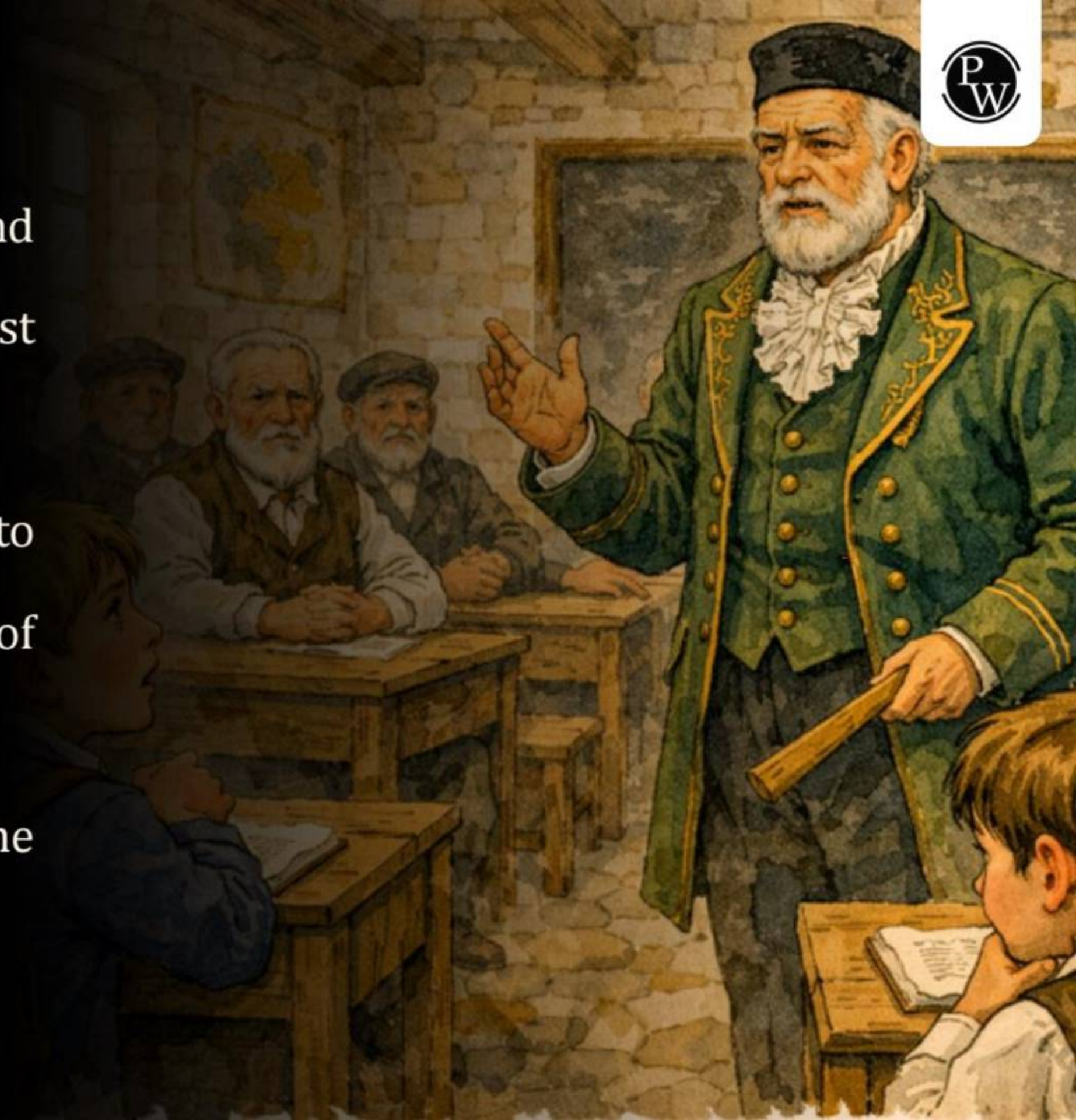
The classroom surprises Franz

- M. Hamel unexpectedly kind
- had put on his beautiful green coat, frilled shirt and an embroidered black silk cap which he normally wore only on inspection and prize days
- entire school wore a strange and serious look
- strangely enough, back benches occupied by the village people



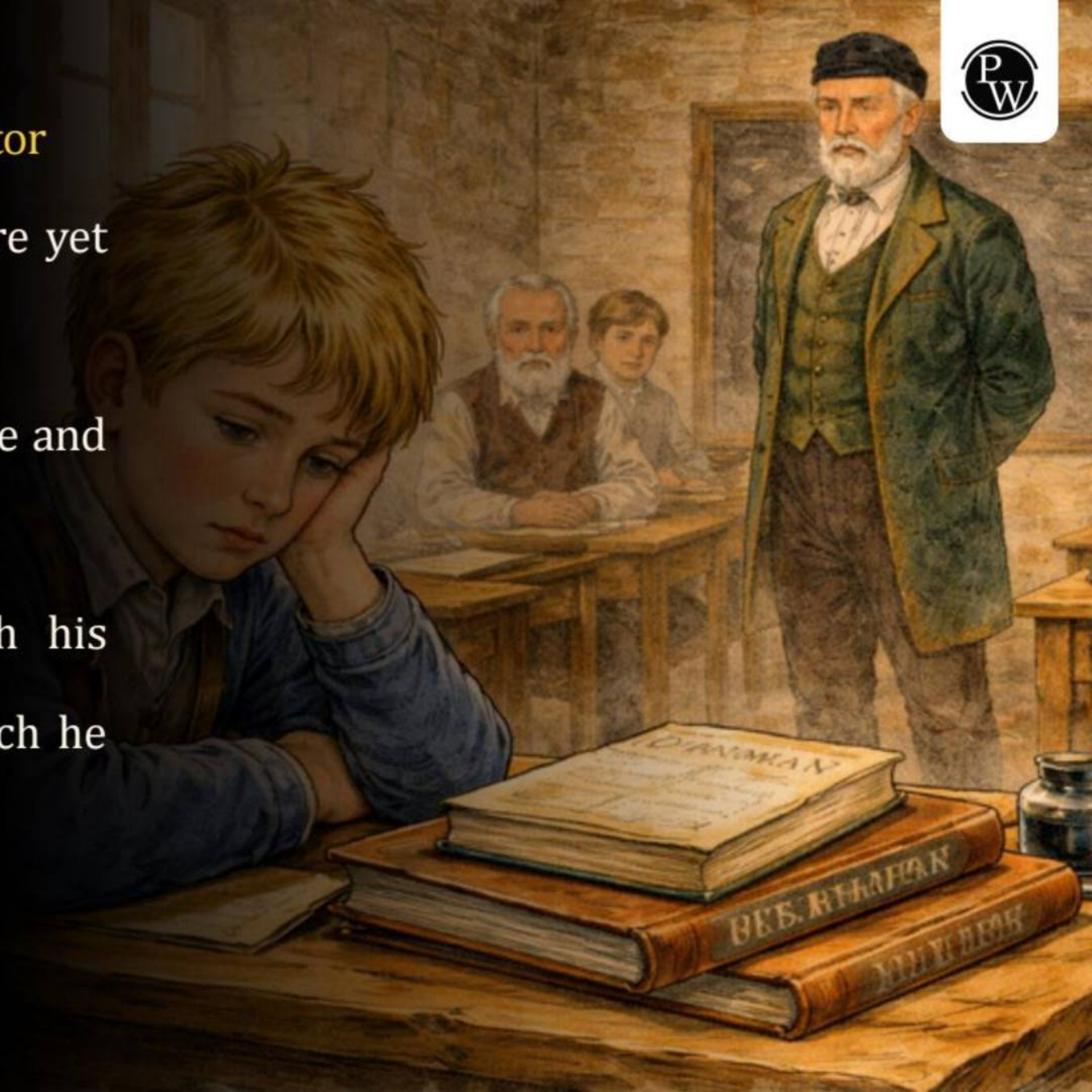
M. Hamel's startling revelation

- M. Hamel demanded full attention and announced that it was to be their last lesson in French
- had received orders from Berlin to teach only German in schools of Alsace and Lorraine
- new teacher was going to join the next day



A grim realisation dawns on the narrator

- realised that he had so much more yet to learn
- felt sorry for whiling away his time and skipping his lessons
- now did not want to part with his books of grammar & history, which he had earlier considered a nuisance

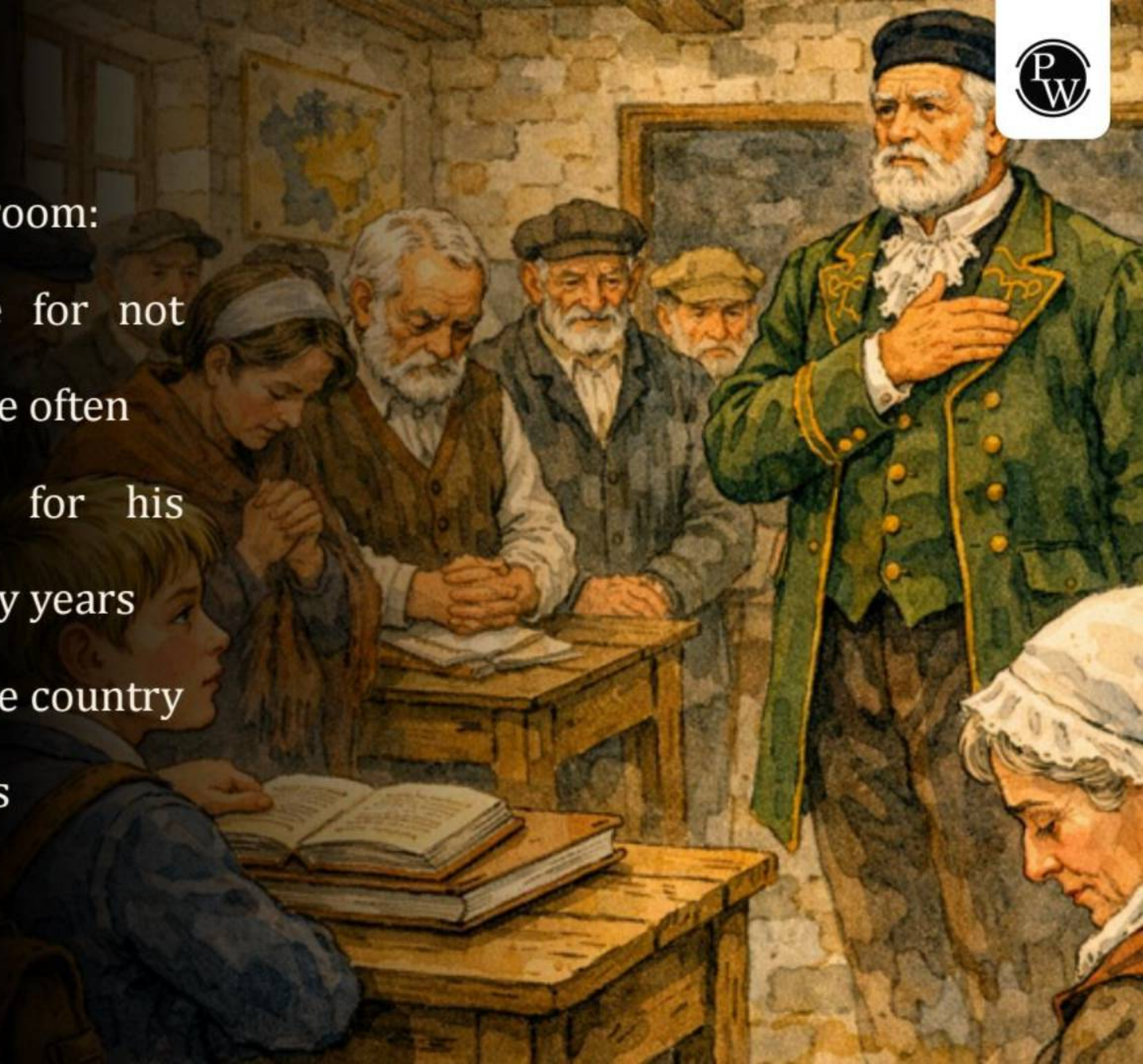


- deeply pained at the thought of M. Hamel going away
- forgot all about the teacher's ruler and his cranky nature.
- realised that M. Hamel had worn his fine Sunday clothes in honour of the last lesson.



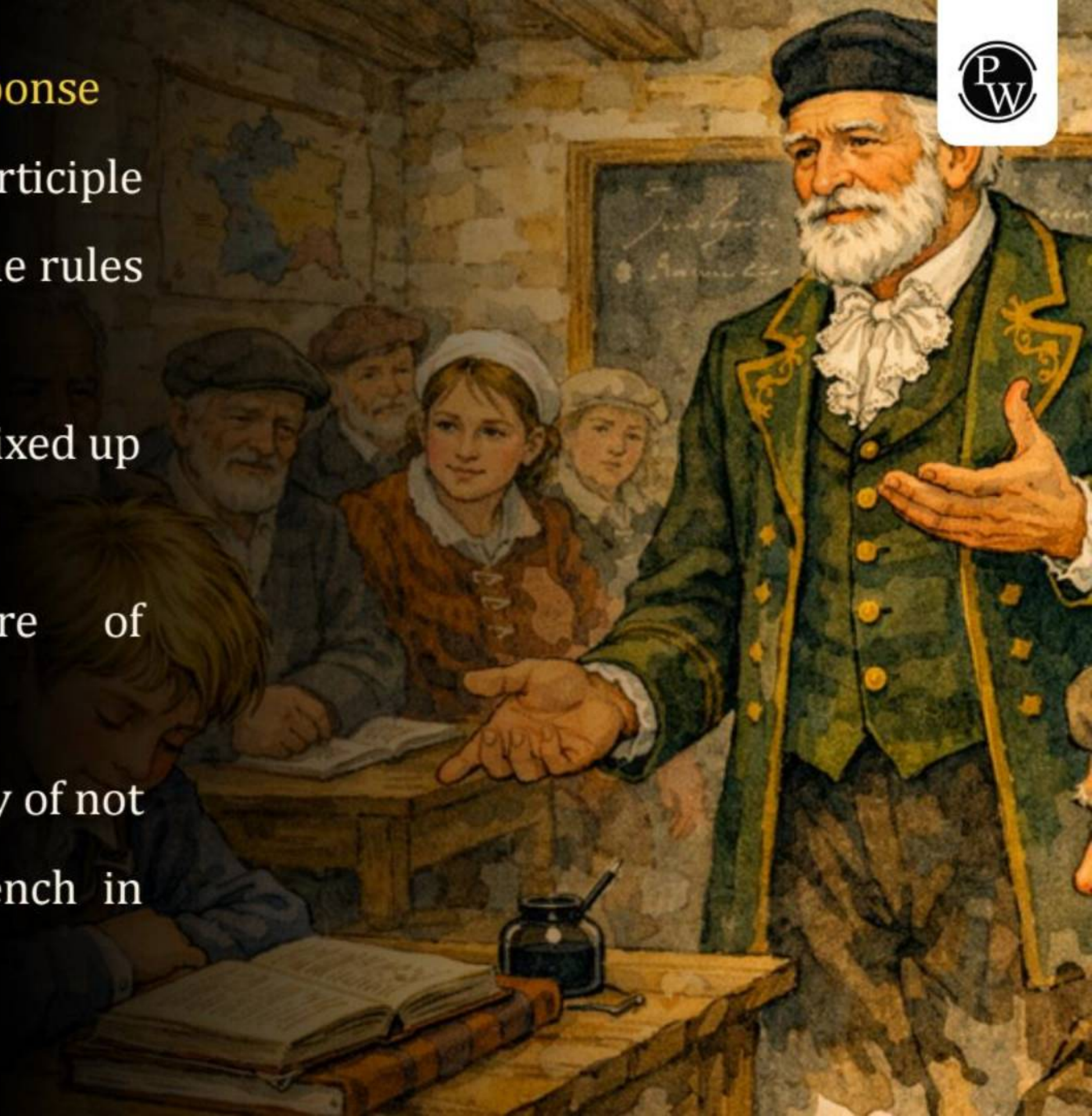
A tribute by the villagers

- villagers gathered in the classroom:
 - as a sign of repentance for not having gone to school more often
 - to thank their master for his meritorious service of forty years
 - as a mark of respect for the country which was no longer theirs



Narrator's failure and the teacher's response

- Franz asked to recite the rule for participle
- wished that he was able to recite the rules flawlessly
- feels guilty on getting everything mixed up
- M. Hamel does not scold Franz
- comments upon man's nature of postponing things
- makes the students realise the irony of not being able to speak or write French in spite of being a Frenchman



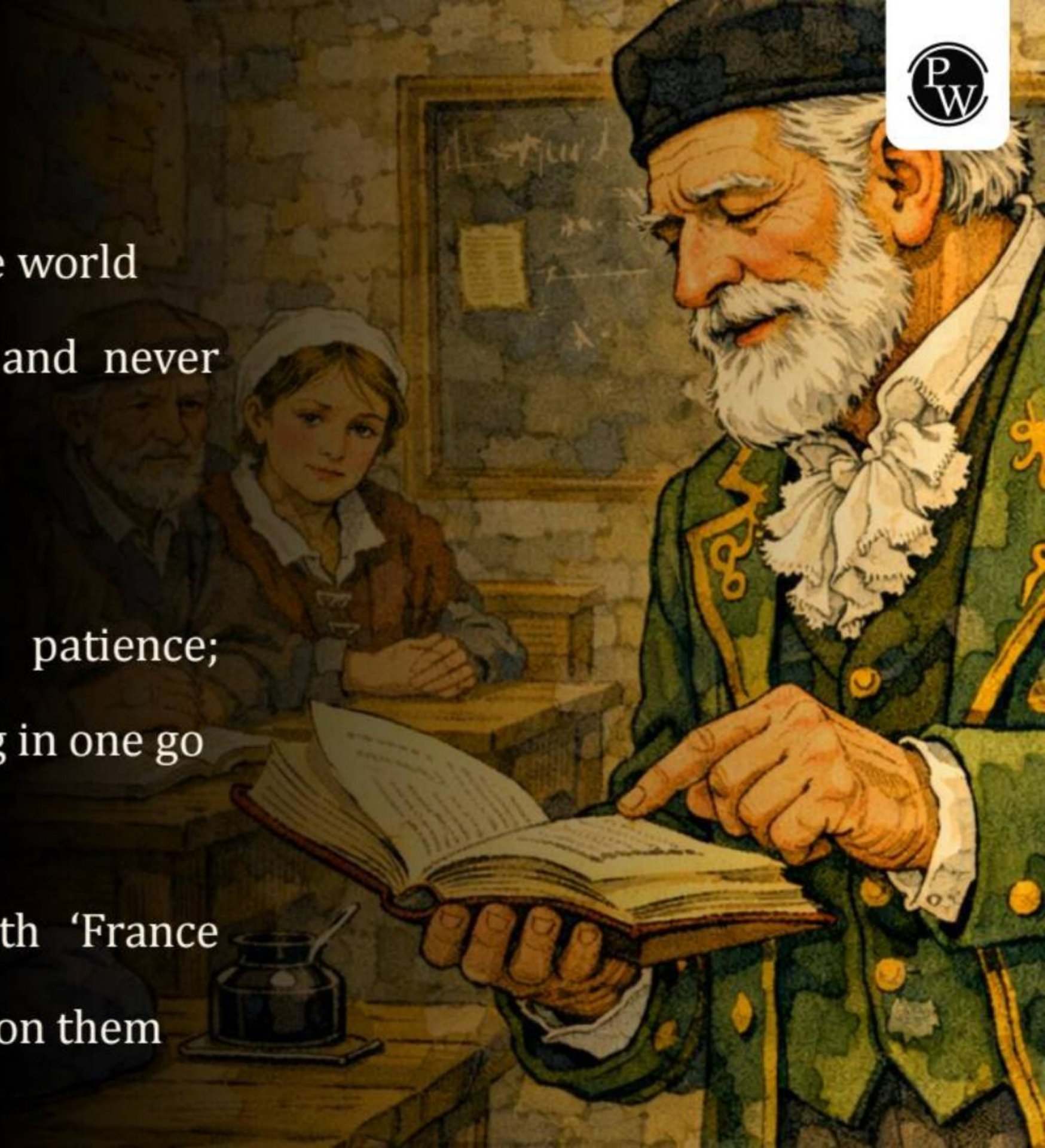
Lack of learning: Hamel's view

- parents ignorant; not anxious to have their children learn
- children preferred to be put to work on farms or mills
- also blamed himself for sending children on errands for his convenience



M. Hamel teaches his last lesson

- praises French language
- calls it the most beautiful language in the world
- asks the students to always guard it and never forget it
- gives them their last lesson in grammar
- explains everything with unusual patience; probably wants to teach them everything in one go
- follows up with a lesson in writing
- gives new copies to the students with 'France Alsace' written in beautiful handwriting on them



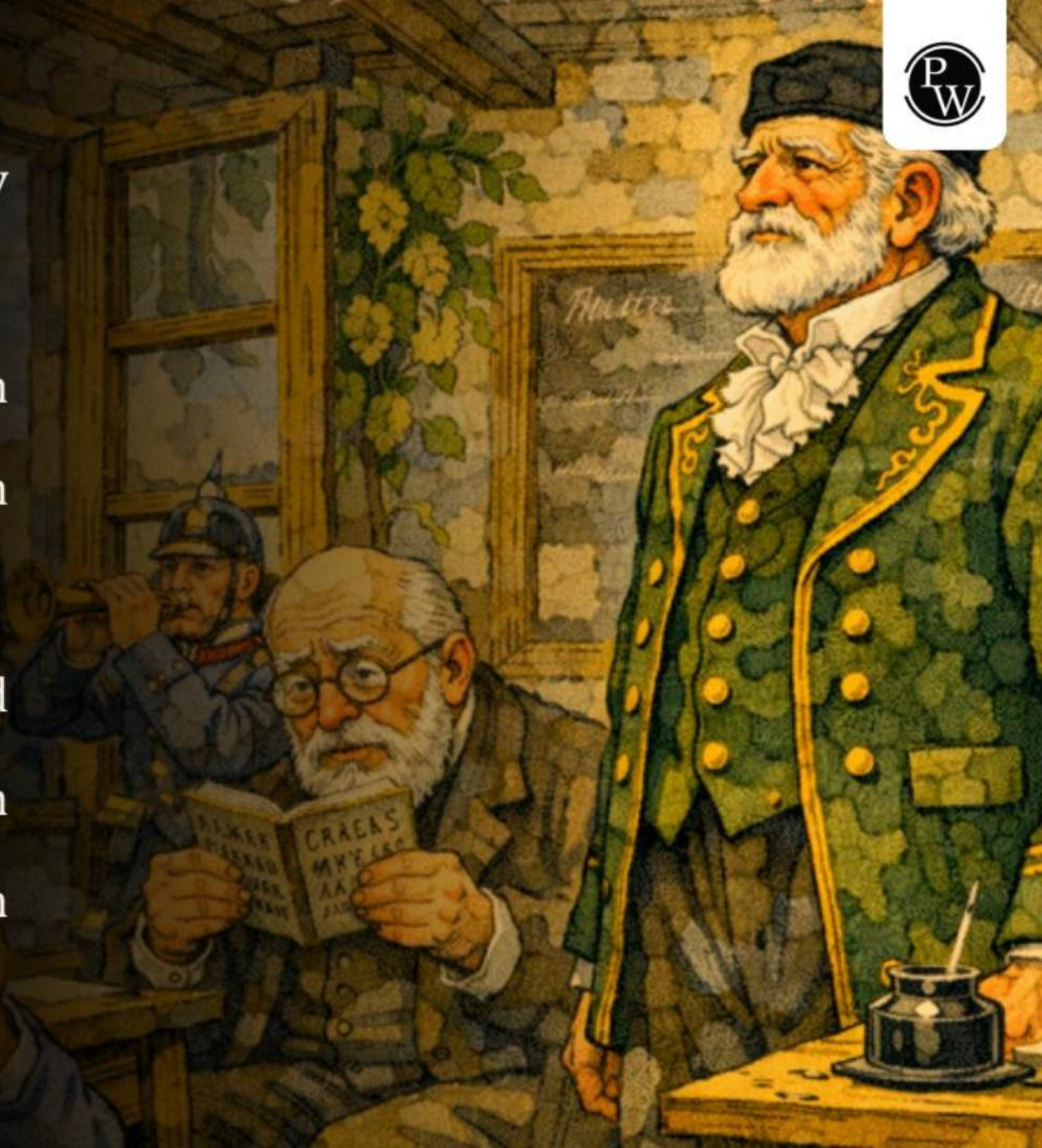
Students exhibit rare attention

- everyone sets to work very quietly
- there is a pin drop silence
- the only sound heard is the scratching of pens over paper
- the little ones also work with concentration
- even beetles fail to distract them



Franz recalls M. Hamel's dedicated service

- Hamel had served the school for forty years
- nothing had changed: the garden outside the window and his class in front of him
- only the desks and the benches had worn smooth; the walnut trees grown taller, and the hopvine planted by him twined about the windows to the roof



M. Hamel keeps his courage

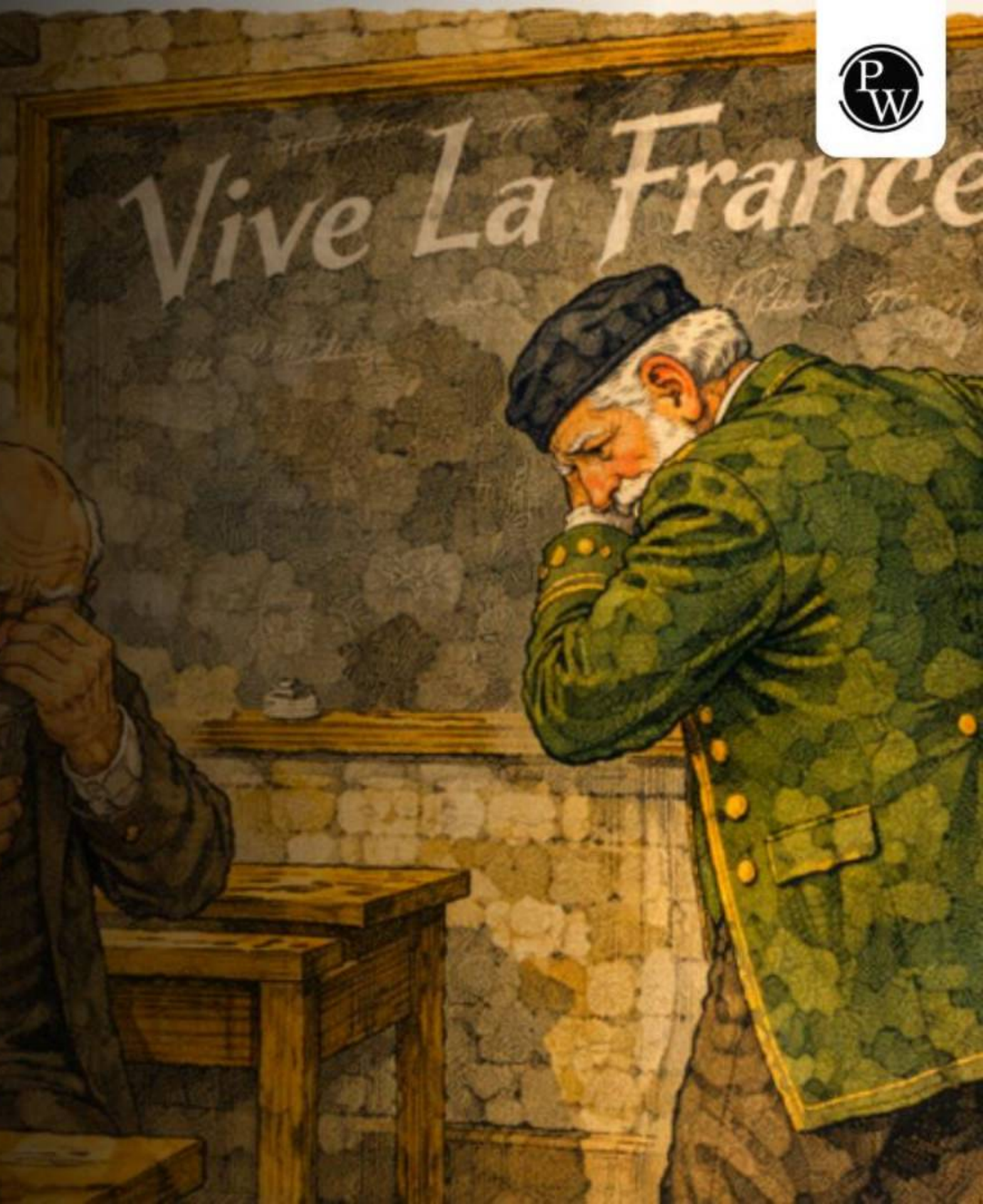
- hears every lesson to the last
- delivers his last lesson in history
- everyone is roused to emotion when the lesson draws to its close



M. Hamel rouses the spirit of patriotism



- as the church clock strikes twelve, trumpets of the Prussian soldiers sounding under the windows can be heard
- overwhelmed with emotion, M. Hamel writes 'Vive La France' on the blackboard
- dismisses school by making a gesture with his hand



Topic: Glossary



- **Dread : fear**
- **Strength to resist : voluntarily refuse a temptation**
- **The draft : conscription for military service i.e., the practice of ordering people by law to serve in the armed forces**
- **Apprentice : a person who works for an employer to learn an art or trade**
- **Bub : buddy; fellow**
- **Bustle : noise; movement**
- **Unison : in one voice; together**

- **Rapping** : striking or hitting against something making a noise
- **Counted on** : depended upon; banked on
- **Commotion** : sudden noisy confusion or excitement
- **Blushed** : became red in the face because of embarrassment or shame
- **Solemn** : serious
- **Primer** : an introductory book for teaching children
- **Thumbed at the edges** : (of pages) have creased and crumpled edges or corners
- **Mounted his chair** : seated or placed himself on chair

- **Grave : serious**
- **Thunderclap : sudden and jolting**
- **Wretches : evil persons**
- **Nuisance : troublesome**
- **Cranky : strange; bad-tempered**
- **Dreadful : terrible; very bad or unpleasant**
- **Daring : fearless**
- **Reproach : criticise or blame**
- **Logical : methodical; systematic**
- **Amazed : surprised**

- **At one stroke : by a single action**
- **Motionless : still; without movement**
- **Gazing : staring**
- **Fancy : imagine**
- **Worn smooth : became smooth because of prolonged use**
- **Twined : coiled or encircled**
- **Angelus : a devotion (prayer) of the church said in the morning, noon and evening**
- **Choked : felt too emotional to speak normally**
- **Vive La France : Long Live France**

Topic: Concept Map



Rising Action

When he finally reached the school, he noticed a stark difference in the atmosphere of the class. To his surprise, M. Hamel asked very kindly to take his seat and announced that this was their last French lesson as the Prussians announced that German would now be taught in French schools.

Climax

Franz, who never liked his books, didn't have interest in grammar and history, now suddenly developed a fascination for them. He even started liking M. Hamel. The idea that he would not teach them anymore made Franz forget all about M. Hamel's strictness.

Falling Action

M. Hamel showed his concern that people of Alsace had not given any importance to French. He declared his love for the French language and that it was the most beautiful language in the world. They must guard it among themselves and never forget it. It appeared that M. Hamel wanted to give them all he knew before going away.

Beginning

Being late for school and scared of M. Hamel's reaction, Franz was rushing towards school when he came across a huge crowd gathered around the bulletin board in the town hall.

THE LAST LESSON by Alphonse Daudet

Background / Setting

The story, "The Last Lesson" is set in the background of the Franco-Prussian war that was fought in 1870-1871 between Prussia and France. The Prussians captured the districts of Alsace and Lorraine in France. New orders were issued according to which German language was to be taught in place of French in these two districts.

Characters

There are four characters:

Franz: The narrator of the story, a young school boy in the French region of Alsace-Lorraine in the nineteenth century.

M. Hamel: The school master of a small village school in the French region of Alsace-Lorraine.

Old Hauser: An elderly villager.

Prussian Soldiers: Forces occupying France's Alsace-Lorraine region.

Minor Characters: other villagers

Themes

- Criticism of Linguistic Chauvinism
- Freedom of Language and Patriotism
- The importance of education
- The necessity to respect and learn one's own language
- Universal human tendency to value things more when we no longer have access to them
- Sense of loss and helplessness of the colonized
- The attitude of teachers and students towards teaching and learning

Anticlimax

As the church-clock struck twelve, the trumpet of the Prussian soldiers started playing loudly. M. Hamel stood up in his chair, trying to speak but something choked him. He turned to the blackboard, took a piece of chalk and wrote as large as he could: "Vive La France!" ("Long Live France!") and gestured that the school had been dismissed.

Topic: NCERT Questions



✓ Q. The people in this story suddenly realise how precious their language is to them.

What shows you this? Why does this happen?

✓ Q. Franz thinks, “Will they make them sing in German, even the pigeons?” What could this mean?

✓ Q. What had been put up on the bulletin-board?



(AI CBSE 2015 C; Delhi 2011)

Or

What was the bulletin-board news that caused a change in the school?

✓ Q. What changes did the order from Berlin cause in school that day?



Or

What was the order from Berlin and what changes did it cause in school?

(AI CBSE 2013)

(Delhi 2011, 2012; AI 2016)

Topic: NCERT Questions



Or

How did the order from Berlin change the situation in the school?

✓ Q. What does M. Hamel mean when he says, “We’ve all a great deal to reproach ourselves with”? ☆

(Delhi 2011; 2015; 2015C; Sample Paper 2018)

Or

“We’ve all a great deal to reproach ourselves with,” said M. Hamel. Comment.

Or

Who did M. Hamel blame for the neglect of learning on the part of boys like Franz?

(Delhi 2011)

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. Everybody during the last lesson is filled with regret. Comment.

Or

(AI CBSE 2015)

The entire classroom, M. Hamel as well as those present in the class, is full of regret. For what and why?

Or

(Foreign 2016)

Our native language is part of our culture, and we are proud of it. Describe how regretful M. Hamel is.

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. What had been put up on the bulletin-board?

(AI CBSE 2015 C; Delhi 2011)

Or

What was the bulletin-board news that caused a change in the school?

Ans. The order of the Prussians that barred teaching of French and made compulsory the teaching of German in the districts of Alsace and Lorraine had been put up on the bulletin-board. This was a piece of shocking information that hit directly the national pride of the French people.

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. What changes did the order from Berlin cause in school that day?

Or

(AI CBSE 2013; Delhi 2011, 2012; AI 2016)

What was the order from Berlin and what changes did it cause in school?

Or

How did the order from Berlin change the situation in the school?

Ans. The order from Berlin sought to replace the teaching of French with German in the schools of Alsace and Lorraine. This order awakened patriotic sentiments in the locals, and everyone reached school well before time. Both the teacher and his students devoted rapt attention to their last French lesson.

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. Franz thinks, “Will they make them sing in German, even the pigeons?”

What could this mean?

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. Franz thinks, “Will they make them sing in German, even the pigeons?”

What could this mean?

Ans. Franz’s philosophical thought means that the Germans can never succeed in destroying the inherent love of the French for their motherland just as they can never succeed in changing the spontaneous singing of pigeons.

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. “When a people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language it is as if they had the key to their prison.”

Comment on the basis of the story “The Last Lesson”.

Topic: NCERT Questions



Q. “When a people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language it is as if they had the key to their prison.”

Comment on the basis of the story “The Last Lesson”.

Ans. Political enslavement is a curse for any nation as it deprives it of its identity. The rulers dictate their own terms and subject the natives to a restrained and confined life within their own motherland. At such times of enslavement, it is the mother tongue, which keeps alive their identity and stands as a symbol of national pride. It helps to preserve heritage and culture uniting people against the invaders. It binds them together, becomes a common source of hope and thus becomes the key to their prison.

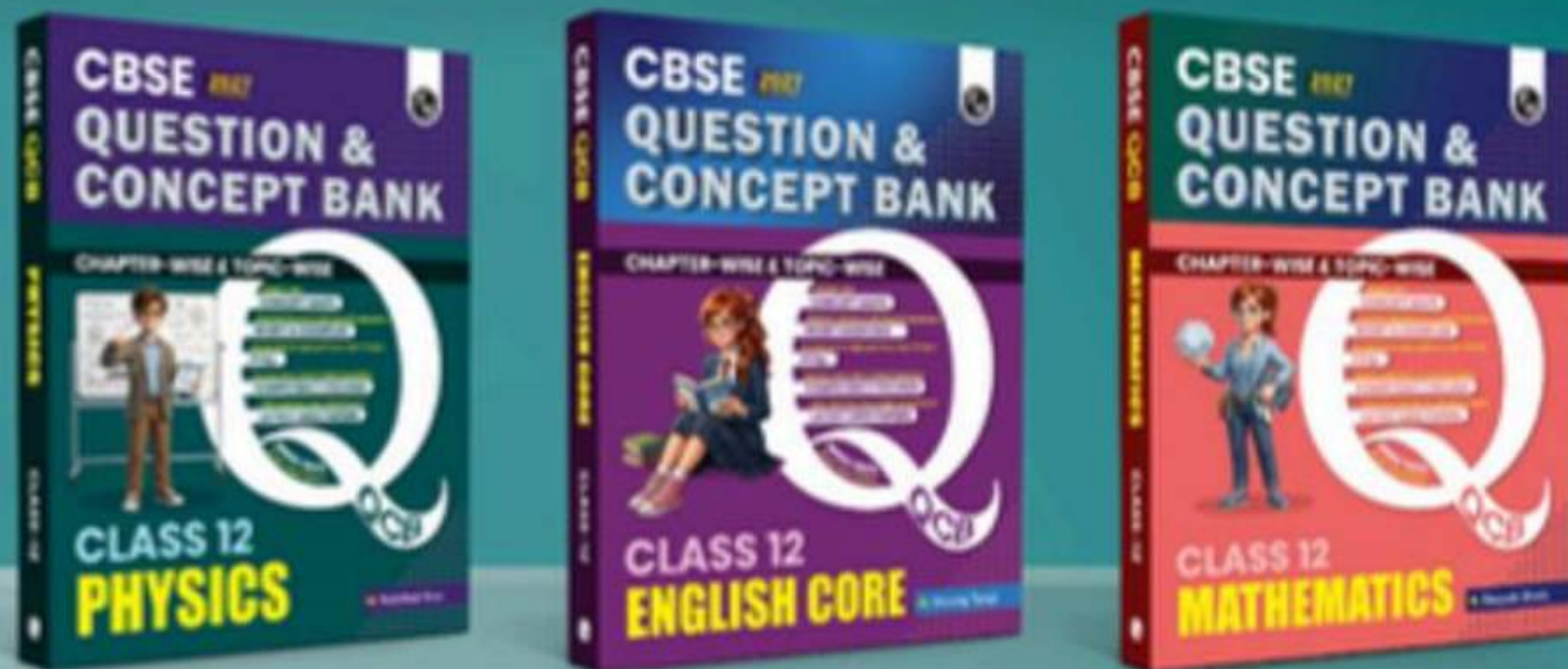
Topic: NCERT Questions



M. Hamel, the French teacher, therefore appealed to his countrymen to safeguard their language. He knew that language had the immense ability to nurture positive sentiments. He believed that if people would hold on to it, they would be able to pass on the spirit of freedom to their coming generations. Then the war of liberation would continue and one day they would be free.

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Thank
you

